

software is part of the larger open source community, the opposite is untrue. Open source software allows everyone the right to inspect, modify and distribute its code. However, free software also forces you to *redistribute any changes you made to it* under the original licence.

Popular open source licences

There are essentially two different categories of licences. On the one hand, there are permissive licences, allowing you to make some modifications to the original software code or sell the modified version as you wish. You can also combine other open source codes and release the final result with little to no constraints, as long as you do not alter the original licences and copyrights. Some common examples of this license category are the MIT license (MIT), Apache License 2.0 (Apache 2.0) and 3-clause BSD license (BSD-3-Clause).

On the other hand, you'll find copyleft licences. The most commonly used one is the GNU General Public License (GPL). If you are including a code in your project that is under the GPL licence, then you must release the final modified version under GPL too. You cannot mix GPL code with any other proprietary source code. Some common examples of this licence category are GNU Lesser General Public License (LGPL) and Mozilla Public License 2.0 (MPL 2.0).

So it is the licence that separates the general open source community from the free software community.

Why should you contribute to open source?

You may not be aware, but open source software plays an essential part in the functioning of devices that you use daily such as PCs, smartphones, and even cars. Thanks to open source software, global tech has evolved at a rapid pace since 2000. Without this transformation, the startup ecosystem wouldn't have thrived.

A key benefit of taking the help of open source while starting a new project is that it saves time and energy spent reinventing everything from scratch. You can simply reuse some of the previous work released under an open source licence. By building upon it, you can create something new and innovative. With open source, you can focus on what's important for your work instead of going through the basics every time.

Another benefit is that it can open many new opportunities in your life and career by helping you become a part of several open knowledge communities out there. Open source is one of the most efficient ways to learn and hone your technical skills and knowledge, because you get to work on highly-technical projects.

You may have heard of open data for sharing data sets for machine learning model training and to access any previous research works. This 'open community' approach helps support various sectors to achieve their objectives. Imagine reviewing and sharing codes for such purposes while also learning to collaborate with very smart people around the globe. Sounds fun.

Speaking of community interaction, by collaborating with other project developers, you come across different people and ideas. And that helps you build your network.

Websites such as Bountysource and IssueHunt offer 'bounties' or compensations for fixing certain problems of various open source projects. This means you can make money by assigning yourself to specific issues and contributing to them. There are other websites as well where you can search for issues that have a bounty.

Far from the stereotype

Whenever someone is told to describe a developer, most people think of a person working alone with machines. But the truth is the opposite when it comes to real-life work. A big part of software development is communication. Yes, you have to write code for machines. But more importantly, you need to work with your peers and other developers.

Communication also entails getting information and feedback from end users, UX teams, product designers and everyone else directly involved in your project. Basically, a developer acts as a central point of communication of a project. All this can be regarded as the first circle of communication.

Outside the immediate circle, developers are expected to interact with different people outside their project or company, especially with bigger development or open source

communities. Doing so exposes them to different opinions and constructive feedback, which is very important for improving and building key technical skills.

More contributions = More visibility

As a member of the open source community and contributor to open source projects, you will get more visibility. That means your professional profile will get more desirable views and requests from people looking to hire techies/developers.



Figure 1: Circles of communication (Credit: OSI 2021)